

FIVE LESSONS FROM BRIGHTON

THE
ROAR BACK
PROJECT



a little book about about big life



WELCOME TO FIVE LESSONS FROM BRIGHTON.



This little book is about a big life.

Brighton had a way of seeing the world that reminded all of us what really matters.

These five lessons come from the things he loved, the way he lived, and the courage he showed every single day.

They aren't complicated.
But they're the kind of lessons
that can change everything.

We hope they stick with you.
The way Brighton stuck with us.



LESSON ONE



BJS

F*\$K
CANC

LOVE

SOMETHING

ENOUGH

TO BE

RIDICULOUS

ABOUT IT



The world spends a surprising amount of time trying to convince us to outgrow the things we love.



The Beginning

There comes a point in almost everyone's life when we begin editing ourselves.

We stop wearing the shirt we love because someone says we're too old.

We stop talking about the movie we've watched fifty times because people roll their eyes.

We quietly pack away the parts of ourselves that feel childish.

Somewhere along the way, we confuse growing up with letting go.

Brighton never made that mistake.



F*\$K
CANCER



Dinosaurs

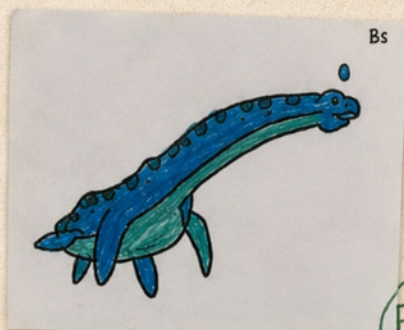
If you knew Brighton...
You knew dinosaurs.
Not casually.
Not "he thought they were cool."
Dinosaurs became part of how
he understood the world.
Jurassic World wasn't simply a movie.
Blue wasn't simply a velociraptor.
Camp Cretaceous wasn't simply
a television series.
They became part of his imagination.
Then part of his vocabulary.
Eventually...
Part of who he was.





Dinos
rule.

He didn't
draw dinosaurs.
He drew friends.



These are actually
Brighton's drawings.



F*\$K
Cancer





HIS PASSIONS BECAME OUR TRADITIONS.

What started as one little
boy loving dinosaurs quietly
became the language our
entire family learned
to speak.





Dinos rule.



He loved dinosaurs, movies, Legos, history, and asking questions that somehow started with Jurassic World and ended with philosophy.

When I looked at Brighton,
I thought I saw a little version of myself.

What I eventually realized was
that Brighton possessed something
I had slowly lost.

The ability to love something completely...

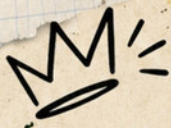
Without worrying whether anyone
else thought it was cool.



From "Fingerprints"
shared on dinoboysc.com

F*ck
Cancer





Shoes.

Sticker.

Tattoos.

Cancer.



Dinos rule.

This becomes the transition.

Cancer changed almost everything.

It never changed who Brighton was.

His dinosaurs simply came with him.

F*\$K
Cancer

Eventually...

One little drawing became
the beginning of

DinoBoy Sticker Lab.



BJS





MM

THE LESSON.



Then...

Carry This With You

Don't ever let the world convince you
to outgrow the things that make
you who you are.



F*\$K
CANCER

LESSON TWO

YOU
STILL
GET A
VOTE.



"Life doesn't always let you choose what happens.
It almost always lets you choose how you participate."



LESSON TWO

THE CONVERSATION CHANGED



Din
rul

The first time Brighton was diagnosed, he was ten years old. He was scared.

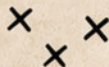
Like most parents would, we tried to protect him from the hardest conversations. We stepped into hallways. We met with doctors alone. We filtered information before it reached him.

When the cancer came back, Brighton had a different idea. He looked at us and, in his own way, said,

"We're doing this differently."

He wanted to be in the room. Not because he wasn't afraid. Because it was his life. Cancer had already taken enough from him.

It wasn't taking his voice too.



THE BIGGEST VOTE

Before long, something remarkable happened.

Doctors stopped talking about Brighton.

They started talking with him.

Nurses asked him first.

He explained what hurt.

Where it hurt.

What medicines worked.

Which ones didn't.

Sometimes it was anxiety.

Sometimes it was something the care team could fix immediately.

The point wasn't that Brighton was always right.

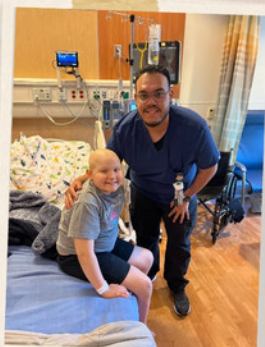
The point was that everyone recognized something important.

The person living through it deserved the biggest vote.



Dinos
rule.





The smallest voice in the room
slowly became one of the most trusted.

During off weeks where
Brighton was feeling good,
Brighton didn't spend his
time waiting.

He spent it preparing.
He lifted sandbags.
He rowed in the garage.
He sweated.
He sang.

Then he made sure to tell
me he'd worked harder than
I had.

He wasn't training for
a race.

He was voting for life.

Every workout was another
way of saying,

"I'm here today."

"I'm going to use today."



Dinos
rule.

You keep becoming

Jurassic World eventually gave way to Star Wars. Not because he stopped loving dinosaurs. Because he already had all the Jurassic World Lego sets.

Stormtroopers replaced velociraptors. Soon our dining room table filled with carefully organized armies.

He could explain every helmet.
Every rank.
Every role.

World War II was always a part of the conversation. He studied battles. Equipment. Strategy.

Sometimes he was right. Sometimes he defended the wrong answer with extraordinary confidence.

Usually because stubbornness had already cast its vote.



TOGETHER, THEY COULD CONQUER THE WORLD.



Dinos
rule.



Paula was Brighton's
biggest advocate.

Brighton was his mom's
biggest fan.

He trusted her completely.

Enough that she could talk
him into almost any amount
of shenanigans.

And when the shenanigans
weren't fun..

When it was another scan.

Another procedure.

Another room he didn't want
to walk into.

Another moment when Brighton
wasn't sure he had enough
courage to take the next step...

He looked to his mom.

She couldn't promise him
it wouldn't hurt.

She couldn't promise him
everything would be okay.

She could be scared too.

But somehow, she could help
him find that last little bit
he needed to get over the
finish line.

That was their thing.

She believed he could do it.

And he believed her.

It didn't mean they weren't scared.

It meant they didn't have to
be brave alone.

Together, the two of them believed
they could conquer the world.

AND TOGETHER, THEY DID.

ROAR
BACK
PROJECT





Dinos
rule.

Remember this:

Cancer took away choices.
It never took away Brighton's vote.
Neither will life. _____

You don't always get to choose
what happens.
You almost always get to choose
who you become because of it.



F*\$K
Cancer

LESSON 3

YOU DON'T HAVE TO PRETEND SOMETHING DOESN'T SUCK



F*ck
Cancer



Being brave doesn't mean
you're not scared.
It means you decide
to move anyway.



It Started With A Limp

Long before anyone said the word cancer, Brighton had already started teaching us this lesson.

He was playing box lacrosse.

One afternoon he came home and told us his coach was moving him to goalie.

I asked why.

"My leg hurts."

That answer should have been bigger than it sounded.

We knew he had been limping.

We thought it was growing pains. Izzie was going through them too.

So we explained away something we desperately wanted to believe wasn't serious.

That week we visited an orthopedic surgeon.

Our lives changed forever.

What still amazes me isn't that Brighton's leg hurt.

It's that he never complained about losing lacrosse.

He talked about going back.

Even before we understood what we were fighting...

He had already decided he wasn't finished.



What Brave Actually Looks Like

One of the most important things we ever read at CHOC was written on the wall.

Being brave doesn't mean you're not scared.

We saw it every visit.

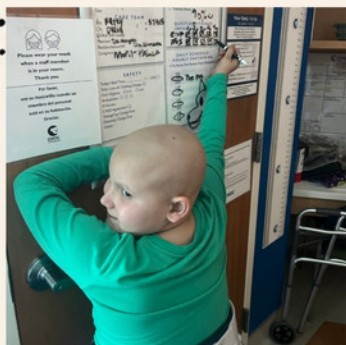
It wasn't only for the children.

It was for the parents too.

Every one of us was scared.

Brighton most of all.

He wasn't pretending otherwise.





WHAT BRAVE ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

He hated being strapped to
the radiation table.

He was claustrophobic.

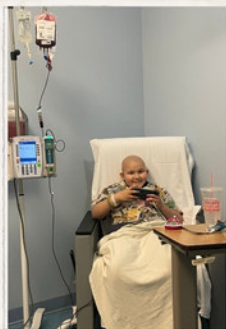
Sometimes we spent hours
talking before he could
walk into the room.

Sometimes we were exhausted
before treatment even
started.

He always told us exactly
how much it sucked.

Then...

He did it anyway.



F*\$K
CANCER



Honesty Isn't Weakness

Some people think bravery means pretending everything is okay.

Brighton never believed that.

He would tell you if something hurt.

He would tell you if he was scared.

He would tell you if he didn't want another procedure.

He never confused honesty with quitting.

Those are very different things.



Dinos
rule.

Fingerprints

“

Brighton slowed me down.
Not because he asked me to.
Because he needed me to be there.
Not halfway there.
Not answering emails.
Not thinking about tomorrow.
Actually there.

”

— Excerpt from Fingerprints
by Alex Soria

Read the full essay in the
Writings section at dinoboysc.com.

One of the hardest lessons cancer
taught me was that not every
problem could be fixed.

Sometimes the greatest gift I could
give Brighton was simply staying in
the room with him.

Cancer constantly tempted me to solve,
optimize, search for another treatment,
or think about tomorrow.

Brighton kept teaching me that my
greatest gift wasn't another answer.

It was simply being there.



Cancer didn't
teach me that.
Brighton did.

X





Dinos
rule.



Mom's Bravery

This page belongs to Paula.
Not because she wasn't scared.
Because she was.

She fought for Brighton with
everything she had.

She challenged doctors.
She challenged systems.
She challenged anyone who
wasn't listening.

But Brighton had a remarkable
way of calming her too.

Sometimes the little boy
everyone was trying to protect
became the one protecting
the rest of us.



— From Paula's The in between
moments on dinoboyssc.com





Dinos
rule.

Always remember

You don't have to
pretend something
doesn't suck.

✕ You don't have to
pretend you're fearless.

You don't have to
pretend you're okay.

♡ Bravery isn't pretending.

Bravery is telling
the truth...

...and choosing to
take the next step
anyway.



LESSON FOUR



A SMALL
MOMENT
CAN BE
THE WHOLE
POINT.



We spend our lives waiting
for the big moments.

We rarely notice that life is
almost entirely made of little ones.



BLUEBERRIES AT MIDNIGHT

Cancer changed
our schedule.

Two in the morning
wasn't unusual.

One night Brighton
texted.

"I'm downstairs."

We sat together.

Blueberries.

Del Taco.

Nightcrawler.

Nothing extraordinary
happened.

Looking back...

Everything
extraordinary
happened.



THE MICROCHIP



Hospice.

Brighton asleep.

Paula and I had spent years convincing Izzie she had a tracking chip in her neck.

She still argued.

We kept pushing.

Finally...

"Izzie...

You don't have a microchip in your neck."

Then he rolled over...

...and went back to sleep.

The room exploded laughing.

Sometimes one sentence becomes a family story forever.



DON'T EAT MY PRINGLES.



W



I stole his Pringles.

He didn't get mad.

He made a video.

Then...

He ate my
sandwich.

The video ended
with one sentence.

"How you like
that?"

Don't eat my
Pringles."

Sometimes revenge
tastes like turkey.

F*\$K
CANCER

THE ARGUMENT.



Dinos
rule.



When Brighton broke his second femur...

It had to be reset.

It was unbelievably painful.

Dr. Misaghi came into the room.

For nearly an hour...

A world-class pediatric
orthopedic surgeon tried convincing
a thirteen-year-old that he knew
what he was doing.

Brighton argued anyway.

Not because he didn't trust him.

Because he wanted every answer.

Eventually...

The doctor won.

Mostly.



F*\$K
CANCER

THE QUIET THINGS.

Toward the end...

Nobody tried very hard to entertain
anyone anymore.

Paula painted.

I built Legos.

Izzie sat nearby.

Sometimes she slept.

We wanted Brighton to wake up...

...and always find someone there.

He was never alone.



Dinos
rule.



MOM SAW COMFORT. DAD SAW ADVENTURE.



Paula watched his face.

Was he hurting?

Was he comfortable?

Did he need another blanket?

Another pillow?

Another medicine?



I looked for distractions.

Food.

Movies.

Legos.

Conversation.

Usually...

Brighton was just annoyed with me.

Between us...

I think we accidentally got it right.



CARRY THIS WITH YOU



Don't wait for the big moments.

They aren't where life hides.

Life hides inside...

Blueberries.

Pringles.

Hospital jokes.

Late-night movies.

Painting beside someone.

Building Legos without saying much.

Holding a conversation that
doesn't matter...

Until one day...

It becomes the memory
you would give anything
to have back.



BSS



LESSON 5

DON'T WAIT TO BECOME YOURSELF.

We spend so much of life preparing to become the person we hope to be someday.

Brighton didn't wait.



LESSON 5

HE WAS BECOMING.



✕ Toward the end of Brighton's life, I could see the little boy disappearing.

Not because cancer was taking him.

Because he was fourteen.

He was becoming a teenager.

He cared about how he looked.

He wanted to smell good and had a growing collection of colognes.

He had opinions.

A lot of them.

His humor got sharper.

There were jokes he and I shared that we knew were better kept between us.

And somehow, while all of that was happening, he was becoming one of the kindest and most empathetic people I have ever known.

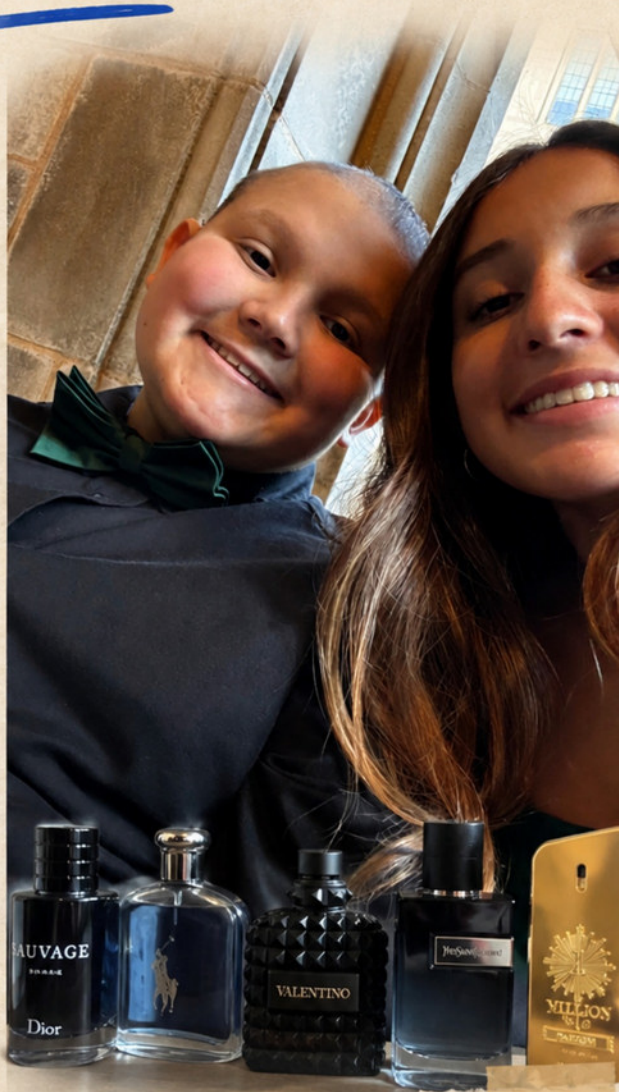
Brighton could read a room.

More importantly...

He could read a person.

He seemed to understand what someone needed from him.

And then he tried to give that to them.



Dinos rule.



HE HAD PLANS.

He was excited about high school with Izzie.

He was even more excited about college.

After spending so much time with Mom and Dad,
independence sounded pretty damn good.

He wanted to study infectious disease.

He wanted to travel.

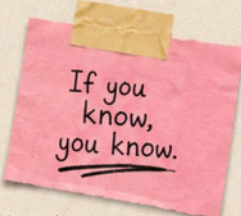
He wanted to date.

And Brighton loved women.

He had a type.

He wanted to fall in love.

He wanted a life that belonged to him.



If you
know,
you know.

We will never know exactly who Brighton would have become.

But I know this:

He would have loved deeply.

Because he already did.



HE CHANGED HIS MIND.

Star Wars.
Then Jurassic World.
Then Star Wars again.
Although he fought admitting
that one.

His tastes changed.
Music.
Food.
Roller coasters.
Travel.
Cultures.
Ideas.
Brighton was curious enough
to change his mind.

• He could argue with you.
Believe me.
But underneath the argument
was genuine curiosity about
people.
He wanted to understand.

And increasingly, he
understood something
many adults never
figure out:

Being right wasn't
more important
than being kind.





WE EACH KNEW A DIFFERENT BRIGHTON.



MOM

Brighton was always Paula's baby boy.
He could fight it all he wanted. He could grow taller.
Turn fourteen. Have opinions. Want independence.
But when the hard things came...
The scans. The needles. The procedures.
The moments when he was scared...
Sometimes fourteen-year-old Brighton disappeared.
And for a moment, he was ten again.
He looked for his mom.
Because Brighton knew something he had known his entire life:
Mom could make him feel safe when almost nothing else could.
She couldn't make the cancer disappear.
She couldn't always make the pain stop.
But somehow, she could give him comfort
when comfort didn't seem possible.
There was nothing complicated about their love.
It was instinctive. Deep.
The kind of love where sometimes you don't need
to ask what the other person needs. You already know.

IZZIE

Izzie knew the clown.
The brother.
Her best friend.
She knew how good he was
at reading people.
She also knew he could somehow
convince those same people to do
almost anything for him.
She knew what he was capable of.
And she loved him
to the end of the world.



DAD

I got the jokes.
The arguments.
The questions.
The conversations we probably
shouldn't have been having.
And occasionally...
A reminder that I owed him allowance.
He kept track.

DINO
RUL





HE SAW PEOPLE.

As Brighton got older,
our conversations got harder.

Politics.
Religion.
War.
History.
Fairness.

The kinds of conversations
plenty of adults avoid
because disagreement makes
them uncomfortable.

Brighton didn't seem
particularly interested in
the categories adults use to
divide one another.

Race.
Religion.
Politics.

Whatever box someone belonged
to mattered less to him than
the person standing in front of him.

He was willing to ask
hard questions.

He was willing to disagree.

And increasingly...

He was willing to be wrong
if being right required him
to stop being kind.

That may be one of the most
adult things I ever saw him do.



F*\$K
CANCER

THE FIRST STEP WAS ALWAYS THE HARDEST.

Brighton did things most adults
would struggle to imagine.

Surgeries.

Radiation.

Pain.

Hard conversations.

Roller coasters.

New places.

New people.

But sometimes...

Getting him to take the first step
was nearly impossible.

He could be terrified before
doing something brave.

He could resist something
he eventually loved.

He could argue for an hour before
doing something he already knew
needed to be done.

Then he'd do it.

And sometimes love it.

Maybe becoming yourself
isn't about knowing exactly
who you are.

Maybe it's simply
being willing to take
the first step toward
finding out.



CARRY THIS WITH YOU

Brighton didn't get enough time.
There is no lesson that makes that okay.
No perspective that makes it fair.

He should have had high school.

College.

Independence.

Love.

Arguments.

Mistakes.

A career.

A family.

A long, ordinary life.

He should have had all of it.

But Brighton taught me something
about the time we do have.

Don't wait.

Don't wait to love what you love.

Don't wait to use your voice.

Don't pretend the hard things aren't hard.

Don't miss the little moments

while you're waiting for the big ones.

And don't wait for some future version
of yourself to finally start living.

Love people.

Stay curious.

Change your mind.

Take the trip.

Have the conversation.

Be ridiculous.

Take the first step.

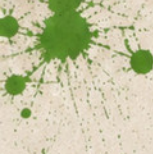
BECOME YOURSELF NOW.

Because a life isn't measured only
by how long it lasts.

Sometimes it's measured
by what it leaves behind.

And Brighton left fingerprints everywhere.





THANK YOU

for loving our boy.



Thank you for being part of Brighton's story.

For showing up.

For cheering him on.

For seeing him.

For loving him.



Your kindness, your words, your actions,
and the way you embraced everything
that made him who he was
meant more than you will ever know.

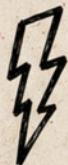
You helped us carry him.

And you always will.

We are forever grateful.



Thank you for loving our boy.





FIVE LESSONS

FROM

BRIGHTON



Brighton lived big. Loved hard. And left lessons that will outlast all of us.



1

LOVE SOMETHING ENOUGH
TO BE RIDICULOUS ABOUT IT.



2

YOU STILL GET A VOTE.



3

YOU DON'T HAVE TO PRETEND
SOMETHING DOESN'T SUCK.



4

A SMALL MOMENT CAN BE
THE WHOLE POINT.



5

DON'T WAIT TO
BECOME YOURSELF.



F*\$K
CANCER



Thank you for walking this road
with us.



THE
ROAR BACK
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SCAN HERE

to share this book,
read the digital version,
or see photos from
Brighton's Celebration of Life.

